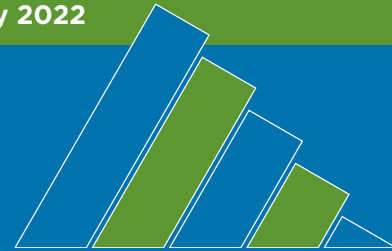


Process Mapping for Continuous Quality Improvement

By Staci Jones, Institute for Community Inclusion



SELN working documents contain information collected in response to SELN state member requests. An SELN working document is intended to share work in progress and may not be a comprehensive analysis or compilation.

What is process mapping?

In its simplest form, process mapping is simply the creation of a visual representation (the Process Map) of a process or workflow. Depending on the tool(s) used and the purpose, process maps can range from very simple to very complex.

While the outcome is typically the process map itself, many teams recognize working through the information to be just as valuable. When done well, the steps of process mapping can facilitate team growth and trust by fostering buy-in and provide a platform for multi-level communication. This can be especially critical when there are a variety of stakeholder groups who may be communicating in new ways.

Why process mapping?

Process mapping can be an effective tool and process used by teams, groups, organizations to:

- Clearly identify desired outcomes
- Identify potential gaps in the existing process preventing a desired outcome
- Create agreement, clarity and buy-in among relevant stakeholders

When reviewing a current process, issues such as the following may be identified:

- Bottlenecks (Where does this process most frequently get tied up? Why?)
- Inefficiencies and/or duplication of effort (Are multiple roles performing the same or very similar functions? Is that duplication necessary? Why/why not?)
- Gaps in knowledge and/or capacity (Is training needed? Are there proper resources in place?)
- Where do errors most frequently occur?
- Other questions your team wants answered?
- Inconsistent implementation or application (Are there regional or area differences?)

“The secret of getting ahead is getting started. The secret of getting started is breaking your complex overwhelming tasks into small manageable tasks, and then starting on the first one.”

—Mark Twain

Pre-planning for process mapping

Before jumping directly into the process mapping, start with a smaller ‘steering committee’ to engage in pre-planning before the process mapping occurs. This steering committee should include a diverse set of roles including leadership staff. Focus on:

- What the scope of your process mapping will be (for example: is the goal to look at an entire, complex system and how each part fits together versus mapping out one aspect of a larger system and/or process).
- Identify who needs to be at the table for the actual process mapping:
 - » Identify a representative cross-section of pertinent stakeholders (based on the scope identified above).
 - » Identify who will facilitate the process?
 - » Identify who will be responsible for recording and documenting the process and using what tools?
 - » Who will be representing leadership and any values/expectations, and helping to ‘set the tone’?
- Identify any desired outcomes of the process mapping process. For example, is it to:
 - » Document a current process already in place to validate with stakeholders?
 - » Update and/or improve a current process already in place?
 - » Develop a brand-new process?
 - » Identify additional systems change(s) needed?
 - » Identify communication, training and/or capacity building needs?

- » Develop timelines based on new process(es) identified?
- » Develop communication strategies?
- Identify the logistics of the process mapping and what tools will be needed:
 - » If in person, is there a space that will allow for plotting a process on a large wall?
 - » If virtual, what tools will be used? Does everyone have the same access?
- How will people who miss meetings stay up to date?
- What accountabilities are needed in the process mapping exercises to assure people contribute?

General Process Mapping

Note: this is a highly customizable process based on the above determinations. Some process mapping can be done easily in an existing group. Others may require more planning and may even benefit from an outside facilitator who can assist with tasks such as setting the ground rules such as:

- Everyone will participate (decide together what it specifically looks like when everyone participates)
- All ideas are welcome (no interrupting?)
- Using consensus or majority rule when making decisions (if not, how will the group make decisions?)
- Does lack of input = agreement? (if not, discuss)
- Agree to 'parking lot' issues outside of scope for a later forum or discussion
- Share the scope and desired outcomes of the process mapping as identified in pre-planning. Ensure there is agreement on the appropriateness of the scope.
- Ensure everyone knows each other and their roles as it relates to this work (introductions)
- Assess whether there is buy-in or an understanding of why this particular process needs mapping? Has it been done before? Is there value in reviewing previous information? (If not, there may be potential 'ownership issues' that arise)
- Start mapping the identified process from beginning to end
- Use the opportunity to 'define terms' (when we all use this word, do we all mean the same thing?)
- The creation of a draft process map can provide a good opportunity for a 'subgroup' to validate the process over a specified period of time and report back to the group:
 - » What is working?
 - » What doesn't work as written? Why not?
 - » Did we miss a step?
 - » Did we miss a key stakeholder?

EXAMPLE

The example process map (see next page) was created to visually demonstrate how to sequence services from the state VR and IDD agencies leading to increased employment outcomes.

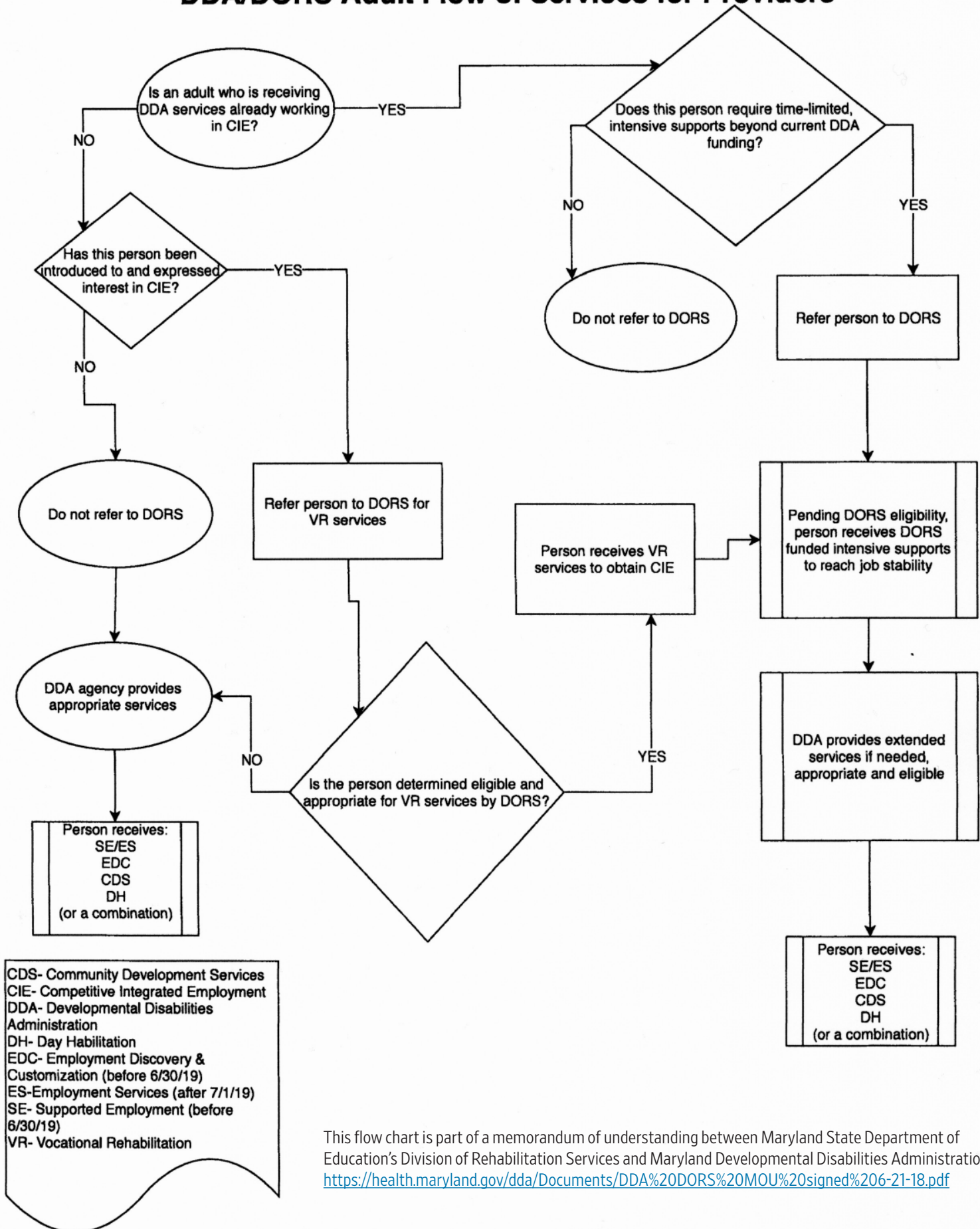
Process used

- A small work group was developed to walk through the process several times.
- The work group included representatives from each agency, as well as provider agencies and case managers.
- Based on the information gained from the work group, a flow chart was developed and reviewed with the work group for further discussion and validation.
- A sub-group of provider agencies that were interested in participating were asked to use the map when providing services and documenting whether the process worked.
- Based on continuing feedback from leadership and the work group, the chart was refined several times.
- Eventually, the chart, along with a signed MOU between the agencies and additional guidance documents, were shared with the larger stakeholder group in several ways:
 - » Joint webinars
 - » In-person stakeholder meetings
 - » Ongoing work group discussion and collaboration

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**“Quality is never an accident;
 it is always the result of high
 intention, sincere effort, intelligent
 direction and skillful execution;
 it represents the wise choice of
 many alternatives.”**

—William A. Foster

DDA/DORS Adult Flow of Services for Providers





State Employment Leadership Network

The State Employment Leadership Network (SELN) is a cross-state cooperative venture of state MR/DD agencies that are committed to improving employment outcomes for adolescents and adults with developmental disabilities. Working documents contain information collected in response to state requests, and federal, state and local initiatives of interest to the SELN membership. They are intended to share work in progress but may not be a comprehensive analysis or compilation. Working documents are updated over time as information changes.

The SELN is a joint program of the Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston and the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services.



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